TEACHER'S LESSON PLAN • GRAMMAR REVIEW

# Past Simple vs. Past Progressive

Finished, or in the middle? A review lesson built around Hebrew speakers' typical mistakes.

| CLASS | LEARNERS | LENGTH | TYPE |
|---|---|---|---|
| 10th grade, 5-point (5 יח"ל) | Hebrew speakers, CEFR B1+ to B2 | 45 minutes + homework | Review: accuracy, not first exposure |

## Objectives

By the end of the lesson students will be able to:

1. Pick the right tense: Past Simple for completed actions and sequences, Past Progressive for background and actions in progress.
2. Use **when** and **while** to show one action interrupting another.
3. Spot and fix the past-tense mistakes Hebrew speakers typically make.
4. Use both tenses in speech (Alibi) and writing (homework).

## Materials

- Student handout, one per student
- Slide deck (optional)
- Two colours of marker: **blue = Past Simple**, **orange or red = Past Progressive**
- A timer for the Alibi game

## Why Hebrew speakers struggle

Hebrew has **one past tense** and no progressive aspect: *I studied* and *I was studying* are both **למדתי**. So students:

- **Overuse Past Simple** for actions in progress: *"At 8 o'clock I ate dinner."*
- **Mix the forms**: *"I was go"*, treating *was* as a past marker.
- **Mark the past twice**: *"I didn't went"*, *"Did you saw?"*
- **Add -ing to stative verbs**: *"I was knowing"*.
- **Skip inversion**: *"Where you were going?"* (Hebrew word order).
- **Say -ed as a syllable**: *"work-ed"*.

Stage 3 (error clinic) tackles these head-on.

## Lesson at a glance

| 1 | 2 | 3 | 4 | 5 | 6 |
|---|---|---|---|---|---|
| Warm-up 5′ | Discovery 10′ | Error clinic 7′ | Practice 8′ | Alibi game 12′ | Exit 3′ |

## 1 Warm-up: "What were you doing...?"

**5 min • whole class → pairs**

*Get both tenses out of students' mouths before any explanation, and see who mixes them up.*

1. Write on the board: **Yesterday at 8:00 p.m.**
2. Ask 3–4 students: *"What were you doing yesterday at 8 p.m.?"* Write their answers on the board exactly as said, **mistakes included**. Don't correct yet.
3. Follow up: *"And what happened next?"* / *"Did anything interrupt you?"*
4. Pairs ask each other about 7:00 this morning and 10:00 last night (2 min).

Keep the board sentences. You'll come back to them at the end of Stage 3.

## 2 Guided discovery: *The Night the Lights Went Out*

**10 min • individual → pairs**

*Students work out the rules from a text instead of being told.*

1. Students read the story (handout Part A) once. Gist question: *"Why does the writer remember that night?"* (1 min)
2. Individually, they underline Past Simple in **blue** and Past Progressive in **orange** (3 min).
3. In pairs, they answer the discovery questions in Part B (4 min).
4. Whole-class check. Build the rules table on the board from what students say (2 min).

**PAST SIMPLE**

- Completed action at a specific past time
- A **sequence** of events (first → then → next)
- The **short** action that interrupts
- Stative verbs: *know, want, like, have* (= own), *believe*

**PAST PROGRESSIVE**

- Action **in progress** at a past moment
- **Background** and scene-setting in a story
- The **longer** action that gets interrupted
- Two long actions at the same time

**Signal words: when** + Past Simple: *I was studying when the lights **went** out.* • **while** + Past Progressive: *While Noa **was looking** for a flashlight, I opened the window.*

**The Hebrew point (1 minute):** ask how to say *"I was studying"* and *"I studied"* in Hebrew. Both are למדתי. Make it explicit: **English forces you to choose, Hebrew doesn't.** Every past verb in English needs the question: *finished, or in the middle?*

**ANSWER KEY • PART B**

1. **Past Simple:** went (out), screamed, stopped, went (silent), opened, noticed, had (light), didn't know, found out, had (a generator), came back, didn't do, learned.
   **Past Progressive:** was studying, was raining, was blowing, was watching, were cooking, was looking, were standing (and shouting), was sitting (and playing), was working, weren't studying, were singing.
   In "were standing and shouting", the second -ing verb shares the same *were*. Students often repeat it; that's correct but clumsy.
2. Past Progressive. It describes the scene and background.
3. Past Simple. One after another, a sequence of complete actions.
4. Looking for the flashlight was longer. Opening the window happened during it.
5. *Know* is a stative verb (a state, not an action), so it doesn't normally take -ing.
6. Both are **למדתי**. Hebrew doesn't show the difference, so English speakers have to choose deliberately.

# 3 Error clinic

**7 min • pairs → whole class**

*Target typical Hebrew-speaker errors head-on.*

1. Pairs correct the 8 sentences in Part C (4 min). Each has **exactly one** problem, though the fix may change more than one word.
2. Whole-class check (2 min). For each one, ask *"Why was it wrong?"* and get a reason, not just the correction.
3. Go back to the warm-up sentences on the board and correct those too (1 min).

**ANSWER KEY • PART C**

| # | Mistake | Correction | Why |
|---|---|---|---|
| 1 | When I was arrive home, my mother cooked dinner. | When I **arrived** home, my mother **was cooking** dinner. | *was* + base form doesn't exist. Arriving interrupts the cooking. |
| 2 | I didn't went to school yesterday. | I didn't **go**… | After *did / didn't*, use the base form. |
| 3 | Where you were going when I saw you? | Where **were you** going…? | Questions need inversion. |
| 4 | While I watched TV, the phone was ringing. | While I **was watching** TV, the phone **rang**. | Tenses swapped: long = progressive. |
| 5 | She was knowing the answer. | She **knew** the answer. | *Know* is stative. |
| 6 | They was playing football. | They **were** playing… | Agreement: *they were*. |
| 7 | Did you saw the match? | Did you **see**…? | Base form after *did*. |
| 8 | At 8 o'clock I ate dinner, so I didn't answer the phone. | At 8 o'clock I **was eating** dinner… | In progress at that moment. |

**Optional pronunciation minute:** if students say "work-ed", drill the three -ed sounds: /t/ *worked, watched, stopped* • /d/ *played, screamed, opened* • /ɪd/ *wanted, started, needed*. /ɪd/ comes only after a **t** or **d** sound.

## 4 Controlled practice

8 min • individual

*Accurate form under light time pressure.*

1. Part D1: gap-fill story, 10 gaps (5 min).
2. Part D2: join the sentences with *when* or *while*, 4 items (3 min).

Students check in pairs while you walk around. Go through as a class only the items more than a few students got wrong.

**ANSWER KEY • D1**

1. was walking
2. started
3. didn't have
4. ran
5. were sitting
6. was talking
7. saw
8. smiled
9. were you doing
10. didn't know

**ANSWER KEY • D2 (OTHER ORDERS ARE FINE)**

1. I was taking a shower **when** the doorbell rang.
2. **While** Dan was driving to Eilat, his phone fell under the seat.
3. We were playing basketball **when** it started to rain.
4. **While** my dad was cooking, my sister was doing her homework. (Two long actions, both progressive.)

## 5 Freer practice: Alibi

12 min • groups

*Both tenses in spontaneous speech, with a real reason to be accurate: if your answers don't match, you lose.*

**SCENARIO (READ ALOUD)**

"Yesterday between 7:00 and 9:00 p.m., someone ate the entire birthday cake in the teachers' room. Nobody saw who did it. You are all suspects."

- Split the class into **suspect pairs** and **3–4 detectives** (two detective groups for a big class).
- **Prep (3 min):** suspects agree on a detailed shared alibi: where they were and what they were doing at 7:15, 7:45 and 8:30, the weather, what they ate, what interrupted them. **Nothing written down.** Detectives prepare questions from Part E.
- **Interrogation (6 min):** detectives question each suspect **separately**, about 1 minute each, and note every detail that doesn't match.
- **Verdict (3 min):** the pair with the most mismatches is "guilty". Spend the last minute on **delayed error correction**: write 3–4 errors you overheard on the board, anonymously, and have the class fix them.

**Listen for:** *was* + base form ("I was go") • Past Simple for a moment in progress ("At 7:15 we watched a movie") • missing inversion ("What you were doing?").

Small class (under 12): you play the detective and every pair is a suspect.

## 6 Exit ticket and homework

3 min • individual

Students hand in the exit ticket (Part F, cut-off slip) on the way out. Use it to decide who needs a second look at the forms next lesson.

**ANSWER KEY • PART F**

1. **was reading**, **heard**
2. b. *While I was waiting for the bus, I saw an accident.*
3. Free answer: one correct Past Progressive and one correct Past Simple, joined by *when* or *while*.

### Homework: narrative paragraph

**Write about a time when something unexpected happened to you or someone you know (120–150 words).** Include at least **4** Past Progressive and **6** Past Simple verbs, **when** and **while** once each, and a scene-setting opening sentence. Underline Past Progressive once, Past Simple twice.

### Marking guide (out of 10)

| Criterion | Points |
|---|---|
| Correct tense choice (simple vs. progressive) | 4 |
| Correct forms (irregulars, *did* + base, *was/were*) | 3 |
| *When / while* used correctly | 1 |
| Background → event → outcome structure | 2 |

## + Differentiation and follow-up

**SUPPORT**

- A list of 20 common irregular verbs (go–went, see–saw, find–found…) for Stages 4–6.
- Sentence frames for Alibi: *"At ___ we were ___ing ___. Then ___ happened."*
- Error clinic: sentences 1–6 only.

**CHALLENGE**

- Homework: add **just as** / **as** (*Just as I was leaving, the phone rang*) and one Past Perfect for an earlier event.
- Discovery extra: *"he had a generator"* vs. *"he had bought a generator"*. What changes?

**Next lesson:** Past Simple vs. Past Perfect, or *used to / would* for past habits. The second also catches *"I was go to the beach every summer"*, the same "was = past" interference.